



# WE HOLD THESE TRUTHS TO BE SELF-EVIDENT, THAT ALL MEN ARE CREATED EQUAL

THE SIGNING OF THE DECLARATION OF INDEPENDENCE (1776)

## IN CONTEXT

### FOCUS

#### The American Revolution

### BEFORE

**1773** Boston Tea Party protests tax on tea imports.

**1775** Armed clashes take place between patriot militia and British forces.

### AFTER

**1777** British defeat at Saratoga persuades France to support the American rebels.

**1781** The British surrender at Yorktown, Virginia.

**1783** Britain recognizes American independence.

**1787** Drafting of the Constitution begins.

**1789** George Washington is elected as the first president of the United States.

**1790** The US Constitution is ratified.

**T**here has been no more daring assertion of statehood than that proclaimed by the Declaration of Independence, adopted by the Second Continental Congress on July 4, 1776, and signed by all 56 delegates present. What would become the United States consisted of 13 British colonies, steadily established

since the 17th century, and scattered along the east coast of North America. They were not just geographically remote from their mother country; most were also geographically remote from each other. Their economies were fragile, and they had no coherent political identity—citizens of Virginia considered themselves to be Virginians, for example, not Americans—beyond an increasingly strained loyalty to the British crown.

However, the colonies were also remarkably self-aware and acutely conscious of Enlightenment notions of political liberty, and they were concerned that their freedom would come under threat as a result of British rule. Unable to assert their own natural rights, and subjected to what they considered unreasonably imposed taxes, the colonists questioned why a distant parliament and a distant king should impose their will on them. Impelled by a series of exceptional leaders, in 1776 they not only rejected British authority, but they set about establishing an entirely new kind of state in which government would derive from “the consent of the governed.” This explosively novel idea would lead to the creation of a new and enduring republican government.

Support for a formal assertion of American independence was far from universal in the colonies, however. Five states in particular—New York, New Jersey, Maryland, Delaware, and Pennsylvania—feared it would damage trade and, if unsuccessful, provoke harsh